

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Burns & scalds

MEDICAL / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Stop contact with the heat source safely. Cool a thermal burn promptly with clean running water for 5–20 minutes while preventing whole-body chilling, then loosely cover it with a clean nonadherent dressing. Seek urgent help for deep, large, sensitive-area burns or breathing trouble.

Do now.

- ☐ **Stop the exposure**
01 Move away from the heat safely. Do not touch an electrically injured person until the power source is safely isolated.
- ☐ **Cool the burned area**
02 Use clean running water promptly for 5–20 minutes. Keep the rest of the person warm, especially children; stop whole-body chilling.
- ☐ **Remove tight items**
03 Remove jewelry and tight items before swelling if they are not stuck. Do not pull away material adhering to the skin.
- ☐ **Cover and seek assessment**
04 After cooling, loosely cover with a clean nonadherent dressing. Get prompt care for deep burns, burns larger than the person's palm or those involving face, hands, feet or genitals.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use clean available water to cool the thermal burn while seeking assessment; keep the unburned body warm. Breathing difficulty or smoke around the mouth or nose requires urgent help. Do not turn lack of specialist access into a reason to apply household remedies.

Watch for.

Do not apply ice directly, butter or toothpaste. Do not break blisters. This cooling sequence is for thermal burns, not every chemical exposure.

People & practical needs.

A child can cool too quickly during whole-body showers. One caregiver should watch temperature and breathing while another manages water and contact with care

Next decision.

Seek professional assessment for serious burns and worsening pain, redness or fever. Chemical and electrical injuries need their own assessment even when skin damage looks small.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

INCIDENT / SYMPTOM ONSET / LOCATION

HELP REQUESTED / RESPONSE CONFIRMED

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

American Red Cross – Burns

AHA / Red Cross – 2024 first-aid guidelines

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/burns/>